

Introduction

Everyone has secrets. And as ironic as it sounds, what good is a secret if you can't share it with someone? But the operative word here is someone, and only that someone. How do you do that? You devise a secret language or code that can only be understood by those in the know. Even as kids, we all developed our own little “code words” as ways to outsmart adults, or even other kids, and create some sort of perceived privacy from prying ears.

Cryptography is this very science of secret communication. The science dates back to the very dawn of civilisation, and over the years has had a significant part to play in everything from war, literature, culture, technology and to even crime. For years cryptography had an aura around it of being an occult practice, understood and used by a select few - shadowy characters who operated in secret and did things you'd be better off not knowing. And then Dan Brown's *The DaVinci Code*, changed things. The layman was introduced to the concept of cryptography and soon codes in plain sight were noticed and understood by all, because you had the right “key” to decipher them. This Fast Track aims to go a step further. By the end of it, you will be able to make your own ciphers and codes. How? By building a sound foundation using the various concepts of cryptography. Transposition ciphers, substitution ciphers and other basic techniques may be a far cry from the sophistication of ciphers in use today to protect the vast oceans of digital information we now create and transmit, but these are the building blocks on which rests this fascinating field of cryptography.

The book starts off with these basics, explaining key terms and other jargon associated with this science. It then takes you on a historical journey peppered with anecdotes of the role cryptography has played in toppling governments, winning wars and changing history as we know it. From there you are put in the driver's seat. Imagine you discovered an encrypted message – a sheet of seemingly garbled gibberish – your mission (should you accept it) is to decrypt this message. It's a matter of national security! How would